

World in Brief: China pushes back at America on Iran; Treasury yields climb



Photograph: VCG via Getty Images

China warned that America's threat of "economic warfare" against Iran and its trading partners would not work. A spokesman called for diplomatic solutions after America's treasury secretary, Scott Bessent, said China needed to "get with the programme". [China](#), which buys more than 80% of Iran's shipped oil, might be in Donald Trump's sights. But America would risk a dispute at a delicate time, with China's president, Xi Jinping, due to visit Washington next month.

Meanwhile Mr Bessent's attempt to tame America's bond market faltered. Yields on 30-year Treasuries rose, reversing some of the decline that followed the Treasury secretary's long-term debt buyback on Wednesday, despite him hinting [more may come](#). "Anything that happens within a 24-hour period is noise," Mr Bessent said in response. Investors remain concerned about inflation and government debt, which this week exceeded \$40trn for the first time.

Volodymyr Zelensky said the failure of Ukraine's allies to replenish its stock of air defence missiles, especially Patriot interceptors, was costing lives. The Ukrainian president's comments came as [Russian airstrikes](#) killed at least 17 people in Kyiv. Ursula von der Leyen, the president of the European

Commission, said she was working with EU member states to provide anti-ballistic capabilities, calling it “the most urgent of priorities”.

Somali pirates hijacked an Eritrean-flagged oil tanker off the coast of Yemen. The vessel is suspected to be an Iranian shadow-fleet tanker, and is the second boat to be seized within four days. At least 17 piracy-related incidents were documented in the region in the first five months of this year. Analysts reckon that the conflict with Iran is contributing to the rise.

The *uss **Abraham Lincoln*** left the Middle East. The American aircraft-carrier’s deployment began in November, three months before the beginning of the [Iran war](#). In recent weeks media have reported that morale is poor and food has been in short supply. Several sailors apparently attempted to jump overboard. The Trump administration said the vessel’s conditions had been “misrepresented”. The *uss George Washington* has replaced it.

The **Trump administration** announced new sanctions on nine mining and construction organisations linked to, or part of, **Cuba’s** government. It also imposed sanctions on three leaders of Cuba’s Institute of Friendship with the Peoples. The White House claims that the group seeks to “infiltrate, corrupt, and radicalise” Americans. Separate American sanctions announced this year, as well as a blockade on fuel, [have crippled Cuba’s economy](#).

Walmart, America’s biggest retailer, posted its lowest quarterly sales growth in more than six years. American sales rose by just 2.6% year on year; while e-commerce sales surged, bricks-and-mortar sales fell. The retailer blamed lower drug prices resulting from new federal regulations for the slowdown. It is another bad sign for consumer confidence in America. Last week data showed retail sales in the country fell in July.

Figure of the day: 2%, the share of global chocolate eaten in China. Now local chocolatiers are raising the bar. [Will China ever learn to love chocolate?](#)

Why English football is in league of its own

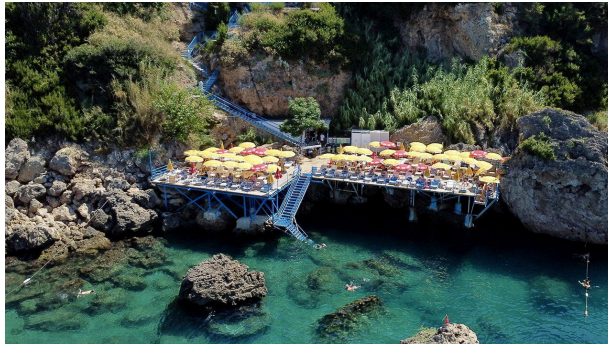


Photograph: Getty Images

The English Premier League, one of the world's most-watched sport competitions, returns on Friday after a three-month break. In that time its 20 teams have spent more than £2bn (\$2.7bn) on players. Nine appointed a new manager. Last week the sale of a 40% stake in Liverpool to a consortium including Jeff Bezos, Amazon's founder, valued the club at around £5bn.

All the cash speaks to [the league's dynamism](#). Its £6.8bn in revenue in the 2024-25 season trounces rival leagues on the continent, such as Germany's Bundesliga (£3.6bn). Exports, imports and competition explain its success. The Premier League built a global fanbase with international broadcasts before anyone realised there was a strong market for live football. It attracts some of the best coaches and players (15 clubs have non-English coaches). And with talent and money spread more evenly than in many other leagues, a competitive buzz sets it apart. Perhaps lethargic British industries could learn something.

The rising price of paradise



Photograph: Getty Images

Turkey's pitch to travellers was simple: enjoy sun-kissed beaches, classical ruins and good food at lower prices than at many other European destinations. Then geopolitics got in the way. The [war with Iran](#) has kept travellers away from the eastern Mediterranean. Disrupted air routes and higher fuel costs have made it more expensive to get there. The data show that foreign arrivals in Turkey fell by 4% in June compared with the same month last year. July's figures, published on Friday, will reveal whether the slump has continued.

Tourists who shell out for the journey are met with high local prices, the consequence of years of double-digit inflation. Some resorts are cutting rates to fill rooms before the end of summer. But holding prices down is difficult, especially for smaller operators because their costs have soared. In a country where tourism and related businesses account for around 12% of GDP, the sector's troubles risk a big problem for the economy. The industry could do with sunnier news.

UN Secretary-General poll cuts the chaff



Photograph: Reuters

The UN Security Council holds a second non-binding poll on Friday to measure support for the seven candidates running to replace António Guterres as secretary-general at the end of the year. They market themselves as pragmatic dealmakers who can navigate great-power competition. The frontrunner is Rebeca Grynspan, a former vice-president of Costa Rica; close behind are Carolyn Rodrigues-Birkett and Rafael Grossi, two high-ranking diplomats. By revealing voting intentions, Friday's poll will narrow the field.

The candidates face a dilemma. Most countries want a leader who will speak up for the UN's founding charter, which prohibits wars of aggression and crimes against humanity. But the security council's permanent five members—America, China, Russia, Britain and France—each hold a veto over a candidate's selection, and may indicate in this ballot whether they will exercise it or not. The world is now [run by bullies](#). The Trump administration, Vladimir Putin's Russia and China may not tolerate condemnation of their actions.

Japan comes under more pressure to lift interest rates



Photograph: Getty Images

Japan's annual core inflation (which excludes fresh food) rose to 1.8% in July from 1.6% in June, partly because of the Iran war and higher import costs caused by the weak yen. The overall annual inflation rate was 1.9%. That is below the Bank of Japan's 2% target, but rising living costs are hurting the prime minister, Takaichi Sanae. According to a poll in July by *Yomiuri*, a national daily, 71% of Japanese are unhappy with the government's handling of inflation. Most analysts expect an interest-rate raise when the central bank meets in September.

Though it would increase Japan's enormous debt pile, that would help fix a more urgent problem than inflation: downward pressure on the yen. America and Japan [recently intervened](#) to strengthen the currency slightly, but low interest rates continue to weaken it. Scott Bessent, America's treasury secretary, has implicitly urged the BOJ to raise rates. He believes the bank will "do what is best".

Fava beans and a nice andante



Photograph: Getty Images

Hannibal Lecter loved classical music. He thought the “Goldberg Variations” by Johann Sebastian Bach good mood music for committing murder. Sir Anthony Hopkins, who played the cultivated cannibal on film, is also a composer. On Friday Decca, a record label, releases his second album, “Life is a Dream”. The Philharmonia Orchestra of London, conducted by Gustavo Dudamel, performs the music.

Sir Anthony, who has been writing music since he was a teenager, finds it a more “freewheeling kind of art form” than acting. His will not put you in mind of the grisly gourmet. Several pieces are inspired by fondness for his childhood and his family. “Bracken Road”, a movement from “1947: Suite for Solo Piano and Orchestra”, is a Gershwin-esque tribute to the landscape of south Wales, where he grew up. “And the Waltz Goes On” channels [the Viennese waltzes](#) of Johann Strauss II. Sir Anthony has a gift for writing tuneful and evocative music. The villain he played might prefer Bach.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which phrase does Lady Macbeth utter in Shakespeare's play as she tries to rub imaginary blood off her hands?

Thursday: Which American air-force base in Nevada is the subject of many conspiracy theories about alien visitors?

*Scars are the price you pay for
success.*

Melvin Van Peebles